

# SETTING NEW RECORDS

Though the Congress shows signs of revival in Hindutva's showcase state, it would be a tough task to dethrone Modi who harps on his Government's development and anti-terrorism planks

■ By Uday Mahurkar

**F**ootball coaches in the country, always short on ideas, could take a few lessons in counter attack from Narendra Modi. For nearly seven years, the Gujarat chief minister has often given the impression that he is leaving his flanks exposed, virtually inviting his opponents to go for the kill. When they do, they end up paying the price, for Modi, as he has proved time and again, is the master of the counter attack. Last week, it was Team Congress that fell into his trap. Modi kept a low profile as Sonia Gandhi attracted huge crowds at the meetings in Mehsana. This followed similar turnouts at rallies she had earlier addressed at Panchmahal and Porbandar. Congress old timers were ecstatic while hailing Sonia as their new saviour.

Modi, of course, had the last laugh on the occasion that was perfectly timed. At a BJP rally organised to felicitate him on becoming the longest-serving chief minister—he beat the record of 2,062 days of the Congress's Hitendra Desai nearly four decades back—Modi virtually taunted Sonia and the Congress. "The Congress won't be able to reach Gandhinagar riding on the dead body of Sohrabuddin Sheikh. If there is one state that has given an effective reply to terrorism, it is Gujarat. My response to terrorism will always be back-breaking, whatever cost I have to pay."

The successful rally underlined the fact that despite the dissidents in the BJP and the Congress coming together to play a powerful caste card by mobilising the numerically strong Patel, Koli and tribal communities against him, Modi remained unaffected. That a chief

**TACTICIAN:** Modi celebrates his record in office with Rajnath (left)



Modi is at his best when launching counter attacks to the Congress offensives.